JACQUELINE IN A JAM

The Sukash Chandrashekhar episode throws up questions about how the 37-year-old actress landed in this mess and whether her film career can survive it

It took Sukash Chandrashekhar two months to get through to Jacqueline Fernandez. When he finally did, the two clearly hit it off. Apart from showering Fernandez with expensive presents, which the Enforcement Directorate lists in its chargesheet, Chandrashekhar also gave her a highly undervalued gift: attention. A person acquainted with the actress says that she did err in judging Sukash, but that he had a "very charming personality". Jacqueline fell for it.

The 37-year-old actress and Miss Universe Sri Lanka came to Mumbai in 2009 on a modelling assignment. Her father, Elroy Fernandez, was both a DJ and a salesman, and her mother, Kim, of Malaysian and Canadian descent, was an air hostess.

In Mumbai, Jacqueline successfully auditioned for Sujoy Ghosh's *Aladin* (2009), which marked her debut. But it wasn't easy. "I doubted my decision to move to India," Fernandez told INDIA TODAY in 2014. "I was contemplating what I was doing here ... Things were happening, but I was confused about what I really wanted." The breakthrough came with *Murder 2*, her first hit. The highlight of her career, though, was *Kick* (2014), which starred Salman Khan and in which her moves in '*Jumme Ki Raat*' were more talked about than her performance. This was followed by another dance hit in '*Chittiyaan Kalaiyaan*' from *Roy* (2015).

In a conversation with Sonam Kapoor Ahuja for *Elle* magazine in 2019, Jacqueline said she did not have any romance brewing and wanted to be financially secure. "You need to have a plan," she said. "But I need to build a business around it for myself—either through social media, or it's fitness or health."



By June 2021, news reports said Fernandez was seeing a businessman from the South. The actress has denied being in a relationship with Chandrashekhar, but leaked photos tell a different story.

Fernandez's lawyer, Prashant Patil, says, "He [Chandrashekhar] was showering her with gifts, but she was not interested ... If we as a society agree to bring the matrix bracket of 'gifts' under the definition of Section 3 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, imagine where this country'll go."

The Chandrashekhar saga, though, makes Jacqueline seem naive (*see main story*). When she first learned of the conman's identity, she is said to have believed that he was the target of a "political conspiracy". The ED investigation has "shattered Fernandez", says Patil. "We should not be so bloodthirsty that before the courts reach a conclusion, we convict that person so badly that even if it is an acquittal, it is not worth it."

So far this year, Jacqueline has avoided one-on-one interviews while promoting her films. But it remains to be seen how long the actress can avoid the elephant in the room as she awaits two big releases: *Ram Setu* and *Cirkus*. ■

-Suhani Singh



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